spaces. In an age prior to globalisation, since the rest of the world did not know much about native culture before the advent of the Christian European coloniser, thenceforth their story would be the one written by the coloniser. In any case, given that close to 90 per cent of the native population was wiped out in several colonised societies, such as the Americas, it had a direct impact on the continuity of their onto-epistemological traditions and systems. This only added to the apocryphal aura that European colonialism had enveloped native cultures in.

Apart from the calculated use of violence, the coloniser introduced linguistic and education policies intended to ensure that the native population that survived genocide was recast in the colonial mould. The Christian coloniser was acutely alive to the fact that language captured a culture's journey and reflected it through its stories, idioms, proverbs and usages, which connected the speaker with the collective past. To remove traces of the past in the language of the future, native children were forbidden from speaking in their languages,[20] a practice that continues in English-medium schools to this day. Children were separated from their families and placed in boarding schools to eliminate the influence of parents and their culture. This way, a 'modern' Christian education created an entire generation of colonialised Native Americans divorced from their heritage, with no sense of belonging to their roots or even their family. Critically, a cultural divide had been created within members of the same family and community, and the only culture the future of the community was exposed to was that of the coloniser.[21]

The locations of these boarding schools were chosen to further the goal of cultural distancing by situating them as far away as possible from the cultural centres of the native society, and the medium of instruction was the language of the coloniser—either Portuguese, Spanish, French or English. Unfortunately for the coloniser, traces of the native culture survived, albeit in the coloniser's language, but with that the essence and the lived experience of the culture was altered forever.[22] While some scholars have interpreted the use of the coloniser's language to keep the native culture alive as a form of 'creative resistance' on the part of indigenous colonised communities,[23] in my view, such an interpretation is, at best, human optimism at work. Until natives fully reclaim their agency, which includes linguistic agency, there is no escaping the fact that they lead incomplete, inchoate and incoherent lives, individually and collectively.